



Shake-up: (Clockwise from left) Mumbai Indians, Gujarat Giants, Delhi Capitals, Royal Challengers Bengaluru, and UP Warriorz (facing page) reshaped the playing field for the 2026 season with record retentions and shock omissions.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

BIG MONEY, BOLD MOVES

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In the run-up to the mega auction for the Women's Premier League, you would hear mixed reactions to the prospect of a major rejig, depending on which unit you spoke to.

Big auctions in sport can be tricky beasts. While they present opportunities to wipe the slate clean and start afresh — which is what sides like Gujarat Giants and UP Warriorz were aiming for — others worried about losing stability and identity along the way.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (champion in 2024), Mumbai Indians (champion in 2023 and 2025), and Delhi Capitals (runner-up in every edition so far) were keen to delay the inevitable for as long as possible. These sides had settled playing squads and brand and messaging value attached to the teams they had crafted in 2023.

These undercurrents predictably dictated how outfits went about their purchases at the auction in New Delhi in November.

Up to the markets

A total of ₹40.80 crore was spent to sign 67 players. To put that in perspective, ₹59.50 crore was spent in the inaugural WPL auction to sign 87 players.

The amounts spent in the next two mini auctions were ₹12.75 crore and ₹9.05 crore, respectively.

Some arrived with their hands tied courtesy of a restricted purse. Mumbai Indians, having filled all five retention slots, had only ₹5.75 crore to work with.

"We won the league last season. See the eleven we have assembled — they are almost the same we had last season when we lifted the trophy. We have managed to maintain our core, and it was a challenge to see that through," MI mentor and bowling coach Jhulan